

The Noble Ten Dharmas

Ārya-daśadharmā-nāma-mahāyānasūtra · Toh 53 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 53 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in English as "The Noble Ten Dharmas," in Sanskrit as the Ārya-daśadharmā-nāma-mahāyānasūtra, and in Tibetan as Phags pa chos bcu pa. It forms the ninth chapter of the vast collection known as the Great Ratnakūṭa, a compendium of one hundred thousand chapters organized around the theme of the "Heap of Jewels," and it belongs to the Ratnakūṭa section of the Kangyur. Set on Vulture Peak at Rājagṛha, the text opens with the Buddha surrounded by a great assembly of monks and bodhisattvas, and centers on a bodhisattva named Pure Virtue, Stainless and Immaculate, King of Jewel Moonlight, suggesting that its teaching will concern a set of ten dharmas or spiritual qualities of particular importance for the bodhisattva path.

From the noble great Mahāratnakūṭa Dharma-door of a Hundred Thousand Chapters, the Ninth Chapter: the sūtra called "The Noble Ten Dharmas," First Fascicle.

In the language of India: Ārya-daśadharmā-nāma-mahāyānasūtra.

In the Tibetan language: the sūtra of the Great Vehicle called "The Noble Ten Dharmas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling on Vulture Peak Mountain at Rājagṛha, together with a great Saṅgha of monks numbering around five hundred, and with a very great many bodhisattvas, great beings. At that time the bodhisattva, great being named Pure Virtue, Stainless and Immaculate, King of Jewel Moonlight had gathered in that very assembly and was seated there.

Then the bodhisattva, great being Pure Virtue, Stainless and Immaculate, King of Jewel Moonlight rose from his seat, arranged his outer robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground at the heart of a lotus, and with palms pressed together bowed in the direction of the Blessed One. He then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "If the Blessed One were to grant me the opportunity to ask a question and receive a prophetic declaration in reply, I would venture to put to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, a matter or two from my own side."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva, great being Pure Virtue, Stainless and Immaculate, King of Jewel Moonlight with these words: "Son of good family, the Tathāgata always grants you the opportunity. Ask whatever you wish, and I shall satisfy your mind by prophetically declaring the very answers to whatever you ask."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the bodhisattva, great being Pure Virtue, Stainless and Immaculate, King of Jewel Moonlight addressed the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, as to one who is said to be 'a monk who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle' — 'a monk who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle' — Blessed One, by what measure is a monk one who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle? How does the Tathāgata designate someone as having genuinely entered the Great Vehicle? And for what reason is this vehicle called 'the Great Vehicle'?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One gave his approval — "Excellent!" — to the bodhisattva, great being Pure Virtue, Stainless and Immaculate, King of Jewel Moonlight, and said: "Son of good family, your intense eagerness is good. Your thorough inquiry is also good. Your confidence in asking in order to receive a prophetic declaration is also good. Son of good family, you are one who has undertaken this for the benefit of the many, for the happiness of the many, out of compassion for the world, for the welfare and happiness of gods and humans. It is excellent, excellent, that you intend to fully inquire of the Tathāgata about such a matter. Son of good family, therefore listen well and hold it in mind — I shall explain."

The bodhisattva, great being Pure Virtue, Stainless and Immaculate, King of Jewel Moonlight said "Excellent!" to the Blessed One and listened attentively. The Blessed One then spoke these words:

"Son of good family, if a bodhisattva is endowed with ten qualities, he has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle. What are the ten? They are as follows: he possesses faith; he applies himself earnestly at the core; he is of excellent lineage; he desires awakening mind (bodhicitta); he desires the Dharma; he engages in reflection close to the Dharma; he has entered into conduct harmonious with the Dharma; he is free from pride and..."

...free from arrogance and conceit; and he is skilled in understanding the intended meaning of what has been taught. He does not wish to pass beyond sorrow through the vehicle of the śrāvakas or the pratyekabuddhas.

Then King of Jewel Moonlight asked: "Blessed One, in what way does a bodhisattva possess faith?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, a great bodhisattva is one who is by nature without wavering and without deceit, who is straightforward and whose very nature is uprightness. Such a one has confident trust in the awakening of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas. He has confident trust in the wisdom of the Tathāgatas, which in a single instant encompasses the three times. He has confident trust in the buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha), which is without aging, without death, without exhaustion, without cessation, and without annihilation. He has confident trust in the ultimate limit of reality, in the dharmadhātu, in the knowledge of all things, in omniscience, in the powers, in the fearlessnesses, and in the unshared qualities of a buddha. He has confident trust in the fact that the crown protrusion atop the heads of the Tathāgatas cannot be seen even by looking. He has confident trust in the Tathāgatas being adorned with the thirty-two major marks of a great being, endowed with the eighty excellent minor marks, and encircled by a fathom-wide halo of light. He has confident trust in what has been well expounded, whether spoken by a śrāvaka, spoken by a pratyekabuddha, spoken by a bodhisattva, or spoken by the great sages beyond these. He has confident trust in this world and in the world beyond. He has confident trust in those who are śramaṇas and brahmins who have gone rightly forth and entered rightly upon the path. He has confident trust in the fruit that is the ripening of virtuous karma, desirable and pleasing and delightful, namely becoming a lord among gods within the ranks of the joyful and agreeable deities, or becoming a lord among humans within the ranks of humankind. And he has confident trust that the fruit of the ripening of non-virtuous karma — to be born among hell-beings, animals, or hungry ghosts — is unwanted, unpleasant, joyless, disagreeable, unbearable, fierce, rough, and scorching.

Through this confident trust in all these things, he abandons three qualities. What are the three? They are: hypocrisy, duplicity, and doubt. Son of good family, this is called a bodhisattva who follows faith. Son of good family, this is how a bodhisattva possesses faith."

Thereupon, at that time, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Faith is the supreme vehicle —
by it the guides have surely gone forth.

Therefore a person of intelligence
should take up the following of faith.

In all worlds faith is supreme;
one possessed of faith suffers no decline.
Thus should a person of wisdom
take up the following of faith.

In one without faith
the white wholesome qualities do not arise —
just as a green sprout does not grow
from a seed scorched by fire.

"Son of good family, in what way does a bodhisattva apply himself earnestly at the core? Son of good family, here a bodhisattva, having shaved head and beard, dressed in saffron-colored robes, goes forth from home into homelessness in the excellent way, with faith. Having gone forth, he trains in the trainings, the procedures, the conduct, and the comportment of the śrāvakas; and he also trains in the trainings, the procedures, the conduct, and the comportment of the pratyekabuddhas. Through training in this way, his body and..."

...speech, and mind — all the unwholesome habitual bases belonging to body, speech, and mind are abandoned in every way, in every aspect, and in every respect.

What then are the unwholesome habitual bases belonging to the body? They are as follows: taking life, taking what is not given, sexual misconduct, harming others by means of clubs, weapons, clods of earth, or one's own hands; flailing the arms, flailing the legs, running, making sudden dashes, leaping, walking in haste, and swimming. These are called the unwholesome habitual bases belonging to the body.

What are the unwholesome habitual bases belonging to speech? They are as follows: speaking falsely, divisive speech, harsh speech, idle chatter, speaking so as to slander others, abandoning the profound sūtras, and speaking disagreeably to those who are like preceptors, teachers, and masters, as well as to those who live the holy celibate life. These are called the unwholesome habitual bases belonging to speech.

What are the unwholesome habitual bases belonging to mind? They are as follows: covetousness, malice, and wrong views; envy and miserliness; craving for gain, craving for fame, and craving for the profit of knowledge; pride in one's lineage, pride in one's form, pride in one's youth, pride in one's health, pride in one's vitality, pride in one's learning, and pride in one's meditative attainments; thoughts of desire, thoughts of malice, thoughts of harm, thoughts of relatives, thoughts of one's homeland; thoughts about monastic robes, alms-food, bedding, seats, medicines for the sick, and requisites; excessive attachment to one's dwelling, excessive attachment to one's conveyance, excessive attachment to one's bedding, excessive attachment to drink, excessive attachment to food, excessive attachment to one's sense of greatness; excessive attachment to wife, sons, daughters, trade and farming, male and female servants, laborers, those who live on sour milk, friends and companions, counselors, relatives, and those connected through blood ties; excessive attachment to wealth, grain, storehouses, and granaries; and excessive attachment to all manner of livelihood and its various provisions.

Through such excessive attachment as this, whenever any of the things enumerated is lost or destroyed, grief arises, and lamentation arises, and suffering arises, and mental distress arises, and agitation arises. In this way, the mind being thoroughly drenched in the moisture of craving, one comes to take rebirth in continued existence. Son of good family, in brief, propelled by the mechanism of mental karma, one wanders thoroughly on the wheel of saṃsāra. This is called the unwholesome habitual basis belonging to mind.

Now, being free from these unwholesome habitual bases of body, speech, and mind, the practitioner gives rise to the perception of a preceptor toward the instructor, gives rise to the perception of a preceptor toward the teacher, and becomes one who acts with affection and reverence toward those senior, middling, and junior in the celibate life. Then, dwelling in solitude alone, he thinks to himself: "Since I am striving to liberate all sentient beings, striving to free all sentient beings, and striving to establish all sentient beings in taming and peace, yet I myself remain untamed, unpeaceful, unguarded, and undisciplined — that is not my part at all. How then could I, merely by my being seen, cause sentient beings to become tamed?"

"I shall act in accordance with the words of the Tathāgatas, and shall conduct myself so that gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, and the like are gladdened. Thus shall I act, thus shall I accomplish, thus shall I exert diligence." Thinking in this way, that son of good family is a bodhisattva who knows shame.

He also thinks to himself: "I shall not associate in conversation with anyone around me — whether laypersons or renunciants — who habitually practices with impaired moral discipline, who habitually practices with impaired view, who habitually practices with impaired livelihood, who habitually practices with impaired ritual conduct, who habitually practices with impaired deportment, or who habitually practices any form of impairment whatsoever." Thinking thus, being endowed with such a sense of shame, three times by day and three times by night he examines himself thoroughly with respect to moral discipline. And by the complete purity of his moral discipline, being free from remorse, free from obscuration, and without interruption in the continuity of the path, he draws close to and abides within the Tathāgata's Dharma of the Vinaya. That son of good family is called a bodhisattva who possesses a sense of shame. Sons of good family, in this way a bodhisattva makes diligence his very essence.

Then at that moment the Blessed One declared these verses:

The perfectly awakened buddhas and the buddhas'
śrāvakas make diligence their very essence.

Therefore, in order to attain diligence,
let the one endowed with wisdom strive always.

The bodhisattva of great wisdom, fearless in diligence,
who relies upon what all the buddhas have relied upon,
will come to realize an awakening utterly free of dust.

Sons of good family, in what way is a bodhisattva one of excellent spiritual lineage? Sons of good family, in this regard a bodhisattva is by nature one in whom attachment, aversion, and delusion are slight; one who is free of envy, free of miserliness, free of deceitfulness, and free of guile. He is not coarse, not excitable, not agitated, and not proud. He is not harsh and does not speak harshly. He is straightforward and gentle. He is agreeable and pleasant to be with. By nature he is one who is inclined toward great works of offering and service, who has wealth and the requisites of life, and who is disposed to sharing them generously with others. His hands, feet, eyes, and the excellent limbs of his body are exceedingly attractive and radiant. When he sees a Tathāgata or the śrāvakas of a Tathāgata, at the very moment of seeing he gives rise to faith and clarity, and through that faith and clarity he attains excellence of spiritual lineage. Sons of good family, in this way a bodhisattva is one of excellent spiritual lineage.

Then at that moment the Blessed One declared these verses:

Just as fire is known from smoke,
and water is known from a water bird,
so the lineage of an intelligent bodhisattva
is known from its marks.

Not coarse, not excitable,
having fully abandoned deceit and guile,
completely pure of heart toward all sentient beings —
such a one is a bodhisattva.

Sons of good family, in what way is a bodhisattva one who desires the awakening mind? Sons of good family, in this regard, when a bodhisattva dwells in his lineage and gives rise to the mind of awakening, if a Tathāgata or a śrāvaka of a Tathāgata properly urges him, properly generates renunciation in him, properly brings him to take it up, and causes him to generate the mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — that is the first cause for desiring the awakening mind.

Furthermore, if upon hearing praises spoken of awakening and of the awakening mind, one generates the mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — that is the second cause for desiring the awakening mind.

Furthermore, if upon seeing sentient beings who have no protector, no refuge, no dwelling place, no ally, and no island of safety, one establishes a mind of compassion, thinking, "May I myself become the protector, the refuge, the dwelling place, the ally, and the island of safety for these beings," and by that cause, that condition, and that basis generates the mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — that is the third cause for desiring the awakening mind.

Furthermore, if upon seeing the body of a Tathāgata perfectly complete in all its aspects one gives rise to joy, gives rise to supreme joy, gives rise to great mental pliancy, and gives rise to mental enthusiasm, and by that cause, that condition, and that basis generates the mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — that is the fourth cause for desiring the awakening mind.

Furthermore, for the sole benefit and happiness of sentient beings, one practises giving, guards moral discipline, cultivates patience, undertakes

diligence, enters into meditative concentration, and cultivates wisdom. Now, how does one practise giving? To those who desire food, one gives food; to those who desire drink, one gives drink; to those who desire conveyances, one gives conveyances; to those who desire bedding, one gives bedding; to those who desire clothing, one gives clothing; and to those who desire ornaments, one gives bracelets, armlets, earrings, ear-pendants, and adornments. Sons of good family, in brief, one even benefits sentient beings with one's own flesh. That is how one practises giving. And that giving one fully dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and through that giving one does not give rise to conceit.

Now, how does one guard moral discipline? One keeps body well-restrained, keeps speech well-restrained, and keeps mind well-restrained; one completely and in every way abandons all misconduct of body in every respect, completely and in every way abandons all misconduct of speech and all misconduct of mind in every respect; and one guards the discipline so that it is unimpaired, unbroken, unmixed, and unsullied. That is how one guards moral discipline. And that moral discipline one fully dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and through that moral discipline one does not give rise to conceit.

Now, how does one cultivate patience? Whether abused, scolded, struck, smeared with filth, bound, thrown into a pit, expelled, or tormented by householders or by those who have gone forth, one endures it and accepts it gladly. That is how one cultivates patience. And that patience one fully dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and through that patience one does not give rise to conceit.

Now, how does one undertake diligence? One thinks to oneself as follows: just as the expanse of space is boundless and without limit, so too the expanse of sentient beings is boundless and without limit — and I alone, non-dually, shall establish them all in the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder.

With that cause, that condition, and that basis, one undertakes diligence, and one attends closely to bodily feelings through mindfulness that remains present with the body. While diligently attending closely to those feelings, one also applies diligence to observing the mind by following the mind, and to observing phenomena by following phenomena. Thus, with mindfulness firmly and closely established in this way, one generates the aspiration, makes the effort, undertakes diligence, holds the mind firmly, and places it rightly — for

the sake of not giving rise to wicked and unwholesome phenomena that have not yet arisen. One generates the aspiration, makes the effort, undertakes diligence, holds the mind firmly, and places it rightly — for the sake of abandoning wicked and unwholesome phenomena that have already arisen. One generates the aspiration, makes the effort, undertakes diligence, holds the mind firmly, and places it rightly — for the sake of giving rise to virtuous phenomena that have not yet arisen. One generates the aspiration, makes the effort, undertakes diligence, holds the mind firmly, and places it rightly — for the sake of sustaining, expanding, not allowing the decline of, not forgetting, and bringing to full completion those virtuous phenomena that have already arisen.

Having thus undertaken diligence in this way, one cultivates the first base of miraculous power (Skt. *ṛddhipāda*). Likewise one cultivates the second, the third, and the fourth base of miraculous power. Having completely accomplished the four bases of miraculous power in this way, one remains for an eon or longer, and for an eon or longer one brings the perfection of diligence to complete fulfillment. That is how one undertakes diligence. And that diligence one fully dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and through that diligence one does not give rise to conceit.

Now, how does one enter into meditative concentration? By not abiding in the state of freedom from attachment, not abiding in cessation, not dedicating entirely to renunciation, not abiding within, not abiding without, not abiding in form, not abiding in feeling, not abiding in perception, not abiding in formations, not abiding in consciousness, not abiding in the desire realm, not abiding in the form realm, not abiding in the formless realm, not abiding in emptiness, not abiding in the signless, not abiding in the wishless, not abiding in this world, not abiding in the world beyond, not abiding in form, not abiding in sound, not abiding in smell, not abiding in taste, not abiding in touch, not abiding in phenomena, not abiding in generosity, not abiding in moral discipline, not abiding in patience, not abiding in diligence, not abiding in meditative concentration, and not abiding in wisdom. In short, son of good family, having abandoned all attachment, one meditates without abiding anywhere at all. That is how one practices meditative concentration. And that meditative concentration one fully dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and through that meditative concentration one does not give rise to conceit.

Now, son of good family, how does one cultivate wisdom? One thinks to oneself as follows: even though I lead the boundless expanse of sentient beings to nirvāṇa, not a single sentient being has actually been led to nirvāṇa. And why is that? Because the Blessed One has taught that all phenomena are without self, that all phenomena are without a sentient being —

because the Blessed One has taught that all phenomena are without a person. That is how one cultivates wisdom. And that wisdom one fully dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and through that wisdom one does not give rise to conceit.

Son of good family, that is how a bodhisattva aspires to the awakening mind. Then, at that moment, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

A precious jewel, by its very nature,
blazes with light from within its source;
yet when it is polished and refined,
it shines more beautifully still with twofold splendor.

Just so, one who possesses the noble lineage
seeks out the awakening mind,
and in the domain where both extremes are fully purified,
Māra shall not come.

Son of good family, how then does a bodhisattva aspire to the Dharma? Son of good family, here the bodhisattva by nature seeks out the meaning of the Dharma, desires the Dharma, rejoices in the Dharma, and strives in pursuit of delight in the Dharma. When such a one sees a monk or a brahmin or anyone else afflicted by hunger and in want of food, one gives them whatever one has — whether cooked food, raw grains, or any provisions at hand. And the necessities of life and sustenance — roots, fruits, grains, and whatever else there may be — one gathers and gathers again, and gives to sentient beings.

Then one goes to those who hold the sacred Dharma and, with reverence, speaks respectfully to them; one bows down, one rises to greet them, one joins one's palms together, and having performed all acts of respectful conduct, one then asks questions in the proper manner, with full deference and respect. And in response, that holder of the sacred Dharma answers each question just as it was asked. One regards that holder of the sacred Dharma as the Teacher, as a spiritual friend, as one who frees beings from the ocean of saṃsāra, as a preceptor, as an instructor. One thinks: "This one seeks me out — I who for so long have wandered in the wilderness of saṃsāra," and

cultivates just such a perception. One thinks: "This one awakens me — I who for so long have been veiled by delusion and sunk in sleep," and cultivates just such a perception. One thinks: "This one draws me out from the mire of the ocean of saṃsāra," and cultivates just such a perception. One thinks: "I have entered a bad path, and this one shows me the good path," and cultivates just such a perception. One thinks: "I am bound in the prison of saṃsāra, and this one releases me," and cultivates just such a perception. One thinks: "For so long I have been sick and this one is a supreme physician," and cultivates just such a perception. One thinks: "I am consumed by the fire of attachment, the fire of aversion, and the fire of delusion — and this one extinguishes it all; this one is a great rain-cloud," and cultivates just such a perception.

And for the sake of the Dharma, for the ground of the Dharma, for the purpose of the Dharma, one disregards heat, and cold, and wind, and sun, and gnats, and mosquitoes, and the touch of serpents; one disregards hunger and thirst. And when one sees others enjoying pleasures, one does not give rise to a mind of longing. Instead one thinks to oneself:

"The appearance of hearing the sacred Dharma will arise for me, and therefore I am one who is happy in this world." With this thought in mind, one does not grieve over that cause, that condition, and that ground; one does not lament or give rise to a mind of suffering and discontent. And free from grief, lamentation, suffering, and discontent, one gives rise to a thought such as this: "For the sake of even a single word of the Dharma spoken by the Tathāgata, I would gladly dwell in the great hell (naraka) of Avīci for a kalpa — or even longer than a kalpa." Such a thought arises, and because one's mind is utterly without weariness, one accomplishes omniscience itself — the knowledge of all aspects — without need of forcing, and one also comes to obtain all the qualities of a buddha not yet obtained. Therefore, son of good family, this is how a bodhisattva desires the Dharma.

Thereupon the Blessed One uttered these verses:

The sons of the Victor, endowed with great wisdom,
who have come to desire the Dharma —
when they seek out the sacred Dharma in full,
they do not give rise to weariness.

Those born from the heart of the Victor,
who seek the sacred Dharma out of reverence —
they hold it with their minds

and accomplish it with earnest application.

Son of good family, how then does a bodhisattva contemplate the Dharma in a thorough and close manner? Son of good family, a bodhisattva contemplates in the following way.

All phenomena are like an illusion, because they utterly bewilder childish ordinary beings.

All phenomena are like a dream, because they do not truly exist.

All phenomena are like the reflection of the moon in water, because they are without substantiality.

All phenomena are like a visual aberration, because they are devoid of sentient beings.

All phenomena are like an echo, because they are entirely imputed and not real.

All phenomena are like a resounding echo from a cliff, because they arise and then disintegrate and are consumed.

All phenomena arise through dependent origination, and therefore they arise and disintegrate and are consumed.

All phenomena are unborn, because they resolve perfectly into suchness.

All phenomena are unceased, because they are unborn.

All phenomena are not conditioned things, because they have no agent.

All phenomena are like space, because they are unstained.

All phenomena are at peace, because they are not intrinsically and utterly aflame.

All phenomena are primordially and utterly pure, because they are not intrinsically and altogether afflicted.

All phenomena are without stain, because they are free from all defilements.

All phenomena are nirvāṇa from the very beginning, because they are free from affliction.

All phenomena are without form, because they do not appear with certainty.

All phenomena truly transcend the domain of consciousness, because they are without body.

All phenomena are without abiding, because their very locus has been thoroughly demolished.

All phenomena are not objects of consciousness, because attachment and anger have been abandoned.

All phenomena are without location, because they truly transcend the sphere

of the afflictions' activity.

All phenomena are like a venomous serpent, because they are devoid of the knowledge of skillful means.

All phenomena are like the trunk of a plantain tree, because they are without essence.

All phenomena are like a bubble on water, because they are by nature feeble.

Thus does one contemplate in this thorough and close manner. Son of good family, this is how a bodhisattva contemplates the Dharma.

Then at that time the Blessed One spoke these verses:

All phenomena are like illusions,
confounding the minds of the childish.

They are not real, but like a dream.

Look upon them in this way, O monks.

Phenomena are like the reflection of the moon in water,
stirred up entirely by a shimmer of the eye.

Phenomena are like a mirror's image —
what wise person would take them as real?

Son of good family, how, then, does a bodhisattva enter into the Dharma that accords with the Dharma? Son of good family, here a bodhisattva, correctly viewing form as impermanent, and because of being free from attachment to form does not directly realize the dharmadhātu, yet through genuine wisdom thoroughly understands all the phenomena within the sphere of the dharmadhātu, and thoroughly apprehends their characteristic marks, their well-spoken definitions, and their well-applied designations. Having thoroughly apprehended those characteristic marks, well-spoken definitions, and well-applied designations, he enters, and enters only, into the effortless path of that dharmadhātu. In the same way, correctly viewing feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as impermanent, and because of being free from attachment to consciousness does not directly realize the dharmadhātu, yet through genuine wisdom thoroughly understands all the phenomena within the sphere of the dharmadhātu, and thoroughly apprehends their characteristic marks, their well-spoken definitions, and their well-applied designations. Having thoroughly apprehended those characteristic marks, well-spoken definitions, and well-applied designations, he enters, and enters only, into the effortless path of that dharmadhātu.

Just as with impermanence, so too with suffering, emptiness, and selflessness — he proceeds in exactly the same manner. Correctly viewing form as selfless, and correctly so viewing it, he is neither frightened nor terrified by form, nor does he become afraid. Why? Because form is aroused by the thorough conceptualization of what is not real, and he knows it exactly as it truly is. Likewise, correctly viewing feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as selfless, and correctly viewing consciousness as selfless, he is neither frightened nor terrified by consciousness, nor does he become afraid. Why? Because consciousness is aroused by the thorough conceptualization of what is not real, and he knows it exactly as it truly is.

Son of good family, consider this example. A skilled magician or a skilled student of a magician manifests and displays before a great multitude various kinds of illusions — a herd of elephants, a herd of horses, a herd of chariots, or a host of infantry — and upon seeing this, a person of wise and discerning nature is neither frightened nor terrified, nor does he become afraid. Why? Because he knows and fully understands that these are but illusions, that they are not real, that they do not exist, that they are false, and that they are phenomena that deceive.

Son of good family, in exactly the same way, when a bodhisattva correctly views form as selfless, he is neither frightened nor terrified, nor does he become afraid. Why? Because form is aroused by the thorough conceptualization of what is not real, and he knows it exactly as it truly is. Likewise, correctly viewing feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as selfless —

— he is neither frightened nor terrified, nor does he become afraid of consciousness. Why? Because consciousness is aroused by the thorough conceptualization of what is not real, and he knows it exactly as it truly is.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Virtuous Stainless Pure Precious Moonlight King addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, how is it that a bodhisattva, while correctly viewing form as impermanent and for the sake of becoming free from attachment to form, does not actualize the dharmadhātu directly, yet nonetheless thoroughly comprehends with correct wisdom the phenomena within the sphere of the dharmadhātu?"

When this was asked, the Blessed One spoke thus to the bodhisattva, the great being, Virtuous Stainless Pure Precious Moonlight King: "Son of good family, there are wise men who come to understand the full meaning of a

matter through an analogy. Therefore, listen, I shall give an analogy. Son of good family, consider this: a certain person of intelligent nature who works with poison will from time to time collect that poison, store it away, accumulate it as wealth, claim it as his own, and use it as various kinds of provisions — yet he will not eat it. Why? Because he thinks: 'This will become a cause that cuts short my very life.' Son of good family, in exactly the same way, a bodhisattva reflects on nirvāṇa, inclines toward nirvāṇa, descends toward nirvāṇa, and comes to rest in nirvāṇa — yet he does not actualize that nirvāṇa directly. Why? Because he thinks: 'This will become a cause that turns me away from awakening.'

"Son of good family, consider this further analogy: a certain person of intelligent nature who works with fire will from time to time pay homage to that fire, honor it as superior, draw pictures of it, make offerings to it, and serve it well — yet he thinks to himself: 'Though I have paid homage to this fire, honored it as superior, drawn pictures of it, made offerings to it, and served it well, I must not take hold of it with both hands.' Why? Because he thinks: 'This will become a cause that brings me bodily suffering and mental discomfort.' Son of good family, in exactly the same way, a bodhisattva reflects on nirvāṇa, inclines toward nirvāṇa, descends toward nirvāṇa, and comes to rest in nirvāṇa — yet he does not actualize that nirvāṇa directly. Why? Because he thinks: 'This will become a cause that turns me away from awakening.'"

When this was declared, the bodhisattva, the great being, Virtuous Stainless Pure Precious Moonlight King addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has taught, a bodhisattva is to remain in saṃsāra alone."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, it is just so. It is exactly as you have said: a bodhisattva is to remain in saṃsāra alone."

He asked: "Blessed One, how is it that when a bodhisattva dwells in saṃsāra, he is not stained by the faults of saṃsāra?"

The Blessed One declared:

"Son of good family, for that reason, listen while an analogy is given. Son of good family, it is like this: a man who handles snakes, possessed of powerful secret mantras and great medicinal strength, will play and frolic together with venomous serpents and take his ease with them, yet none of this will cause those serpents to cut short his life. And why is that? It is because of his

wisdom, his skillful means, his righteous secret mantras, and his great medicinal strength."

When this was declared, the bodhisattva, the great being, Virtuous Stainless Pure Precious Moonlight King addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, it is wondrous that bodhisattvas, those great beings, neither actualize nirvāṇa nor are stained by the faults of saṃsāra. Blessed One, this is wondrous! Sugata, this is wondrous! Blessed One, this is most wondrous! Sugata, this is most wondrous! Blessed One, I go for refuge to those bodhisattvas. Blessed One, whatever sentient beings, upon hearing this Dharma teaching, gain even a single moment of clear faith — the roots of virtue they thereby acquire are not small in benefit. Blessed One, whatever sons of good family and daughters of good family listen when this Dharma teaching is expounded will come to receive a prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, it is exactly so. It is just as you have said: whatever sons of good family and daughters of good family listen when this Dharma teaching is expounded will come to receive a prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

When this Dharma teaching was expounded, those five hundred monks, without grasping, were liberated in mind from all defilements. Those whose minds were thus liberated rose from their seats, arranged their robes over one shoulder, placed their right knees on the ground, and, turning toward the Blessed One, bowed with palms pressed together and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, bodhisattvas, those great beings, are worthy of veneration. Sugata, bodhisattvas, those great beings, are worthy of veneration."

The Blessed One declared: "Monks, it is exactly so. It is just as you have said."

Then at that moment the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Those of great renown, skilled in skillful means,
endowed with wisdom supremely exalted,
who have transcended in truth all the grounds
traversed by the hearers —

who, though they know precisely and truly
that the aggregates arise, perish, and are exhausted,
yet seeing these wretched wandering beings

refuse to pass beyond sorrow —

those of great wisdom are worthy of veneration,
the fearless ones are worthy of veneration,
those of broad and clear vision are worthy of veneration,
the sons of the Victor are worthy of veneration.

Son of good family, in this way a bodhisattva enters into conduct that accords with the Dharma.

Son of good family, in what way is a bodhisattva free from pride and from excessive pride? Son of good family, what is called pride is this: one competes with others, thinking, "I am incomparable to others in lineage, clan, physical form, retinue, gold, wealth, possessions of any kind, in herds of elephants, herds of horses, arrays of chariots, or troops of soldiers," and thereby renders one's mind arrogant. That is what is called pride.

What is called excessive pride is this: one regards oneself as superior to others in lineage, clan, physical form, retinue,

gold, wealth, and abundant grain, or in herds of elephants, herds of horses, arrays of chariots, or troops of soldiers, and whose mind on account of this becomes swollen with arrogance and refuses to bow down — that is what is called excessive pride. Because a bodhisattva is free from all of these, he is therefore said to be free from pride and from excessive pride.

Then at that moment the Blessed One declared these verses:

Free from pride and excessive pride, ever possessed of a mind of loving-kindness,
endowed with a heart of compassion, and heedful toward all beings —
this foremost and noble-minded hero walks for alms in this broad world
and proclaims what is of benefit to gods and humans alike.

End of the Second Section, the Final One.

Son of good family, in what way is a bodhisattva skilled in understanding the intended meaning of what has been spoken with a hidden intention? Son of good family, when the Tathāgata has spoken profound sūtras with a hidden intention, a bodhisattva does not cling to the mere literal surface of those words. And which are those teachings spoken by the Tathāgata with a hidden intention? They are as follows.

When it is said, "The Tathāgata has prophesied śrāvakas to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "Ānanda, I shall take to my back the corpse," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "I am old and worn and broken down — therefore seek out someone to attend to me," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "Son of Maudgalyāyana, go to the king of physicians Jīvaka and obtain some eye medicine, and eat it," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "The Tathāgata engages in verbal dispute together with other tīrthikas and wandering ascetics," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "A thorn from a khadira thicket pierced the Tathāgata's foot," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "Devadatta, who is not a noble person, has for a long time been the Tathāgata's assassin, his instigator of harm, his adversary, and his enemy," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "The Tathāgata entered the brahmin village of Pañcaśāla to seek alms and came out again as if washing an empty bowl," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "The brahmin girl, in her arrogance, bound a wooden bowl to her belly and slandered the Tathāgata," one does not take this literally.

When it is said, "When the Tathāgata agreed to spend the rains retreat in the land of Verañjā, he was fed horse-fodder barley for three months," one does not take this literally.

When this had been declared, the bodhisattva and great being Virtuous, Stainless, Perfectly Pure, Jewel Moonlight King addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, how should one understand the Tathāgata's prophecy of śrāvakas to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, whatever prophecy I have given to śrāvakas regarding unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening was given as a prophecy made with reference to their lineage. "

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, even if śrāvakas who have exhausted all defilements and whose thoroughly linking connection to continued existence has been entirely severed possess a lineage — how will they ever come to fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, therefore listen to this simile. Son of good family, it is like this:

"Consider, for example, a king of the royal caste who has been consecrated with the royal anointment, and he has a son. That son is studying all the crafts and manual arts, but because he is dull-witted and not sharp-minded, he studies later what ought to be studied first, and studies first what ought to be studied later. Son of good family, what do you think? On that account, should one say of him, 'This is not the son of the king'?"

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, that is not so. Sugata, that is not so. He would still be called the son of the king."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in the same way, a bodhisattva of good lineage who is dull-witted first exhausts the afflictions through the path of meditation, and only thereafter fully and perfectly awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Son of good family, what do you think? Should one say of him, 'On that account he will not fully and perfectly awaken'?"

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, I would not dare say that, except out of great presumption. Sentient beings who would say such a thing have not been seen to be correct anywhere in a world that includes gods, māras, and brahmins — in a world with gods, humans, and asuras."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen to yet another simile. Son of good family, what do you think? A bodhisattva dwelling on the tenth ground — does he enter the heart of awakening with the afflictive obscurations exhausted, or without them being exhausted?"

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, with them exhausted. Sugata, with them exhausted."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, what do you think? Should one say of him, 'On that account he will not fully and perfectly awaken'?"

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, he will fully and perfectly awaken. Sugata, he will fully and perfectly awaken."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, this case too should be regarded in a like manner."

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, you have said, 'Ānanda, if I were to lie down as a corpse' — how should that be understood?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, I said those words out of compassion for people of future times, thinking: if even the Tathāgata's body, which is as hard as a vajra, were laid out as a corpse, how much more so for others? Yet some foolish people take those words at face value and say that the Tathāgata's body was laid out as a corpse. Such people bring ruin upon themselves and bring ruin upon others. The Tathāgata spoke with that intention in mind, and that is why he spoke those words."

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, you have said, 'I am old and decrepit and worn — seek care and attendance for me.' How should that be understood?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, that too I said out of compassion for people of future times, so that they would not be impoverished — meaning that the Tathāgata has not authorized those elderly, decrepit, and worn śrāvakas of mine who need bodily care and attendance to go without such support. With that intention the Tathāgata spoke those words. Yet some foolish people take it at face value and say that the Tathāgata himself became old and decrepit and worn. Such people too bring ruin upon themselves and bring ruin upon others."

The questioner replied:

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the Blessed One said, 'Go, son of Maudgalyāyana, to the king of physicians Jīvaka and fetch medicine — and eat.' How should that be understood?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, that too I said out of compassion for people of future times, so that they would not be impoverished — meaning that the Tathāgata has not authorized those of my śrāvakas who will require medicine to go without it. With that intention the Tathāgata spoke those words. Yet some foolish people, even when the king of physicians Jīvaka showed care and concern for the monk Maudgalyāyana and inquired after him attentively, take it at face value — seeing only that a medicine for illness was prescribed at length — and think, 'The Tathāgata himself was sick in body,' and find fault even with the Tathāgata's body. If such carelessness as this were to arise even in those who see the Dharma, what need is there to speak of ordinary people? Such people take the literal meaning alone, and they too bring ruin upon themselves and bring ruin upon others."

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, it was said, 'The Tathāgata disputes in words with other non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), wandering ascetics, and

mendicants.' How should that be understood?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, that too I said out of compassion — for the sake of people of future times who might think: 'If even the Tathāgata himself had enemies and opponents, what need is there to speak of us?' Yet some foolish people take it literally and say, 'The Tathāgata himself had enemies and opponents.' Son of good family, if even a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) of but modest wholesome roots has no enemies or opponents, what need is there to speak of the Tathāgata, who possesses a great river of merit?"

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, it was said, 'A thorn of acacia pierced the Tathāgata's foot.' How should that be understood?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the Tathāgata demonstrated that karma is something one must claim as one's own — teaching that if even the Tathāgata himself has deeds performed in the past, what need is there to speak of others? Seeing that through such a cause, such a condition, and such a basis, people would come to feel no pleasure or delight in evil karma, the Tathāgata demonstrated that karma is something one must claim as one's own. Yet some foolish people take it literally and say, 'A thorn of acacia pierced the Tathāgata's foot.' Such people too bring ruin upon themselves and bring ruin upon others."

The questioner replied: "Blessed One, it was said, 'The ignoble person Devadatta has long been the Tathāgata's persecutor, adversary, opponent, and enemy.' How should that be understood?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, if there had been no noble Devadatta, not a single one of the Tathāgata's qualities as a buddha would have become manifest. Son of good family, it is precisely because the noble Devadatta challenged, created difficulties for, and questioned the Tathāgata that the Tathāgata's qualities as a buddha became manifest. Son of good family, thinking 'By the force of royal speech this noble Devadatta shall crush the Tathāgata,' he released in the midst of the town a great elephant named Dhanapālaka in a state of rut — and the Tathāgata tamed it, brought it fully under control, and made it gentle.

Ordinary people in great numbers, upon seeing this, were filled with wonder and amazement, and took refuge in the Three Jewels — that is, the Jewel of the Buddha, the Jewel of the Dharma, and the Jewel of the Saṅgha. And that, too, should be understood as an expression of the noble Devadatta's personal

power as a great being. But among those people, the foolish ones said: "What a shame — Devadatta is the Tathāgata's enemy, an adversary, an opponent!" and took the words at mere face value.

Likewise, during the five hundred lifetimes in which the Tathāgata was a bodhisattva, all the harm that the noble Devadatta did to him was done for the very purpose of displaying all the qualities of a bodhisattva. Yet even so, certain foolish people said: "What a shame — Devadatta is the Tathāgata's enemy, an adversary, an opponent!" taking the words at their face value alone. Those people, on account of that very basis, will, when this body perishes, be reborn among hell-beings, animals, and hungry ghosts. And why is that? Because the noble Devadatta has accumulated a great mass of merit, has accumulated a great root of virtue, has served many Victors with exceptional devotion, has generated roots of virtue, has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle, has leaned toward the great awakening, has flowed toward the great awakening, has come down into the great awakening, and is close to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Therefore those who have generated a mind of aversion toward him will, when this body perishes, be reborn among hell-beings, animals, and hungry ghosts.

Then it was asked: "Blessed One, how are we to understand the statement that the Tathāgata went out from the brahmin quarter just as one emerges having washed an alms bowl, having entered it for the sake of alms?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, I too showed such a thing, having looked to the people of later times. And why? Because the Tathāgata is entirely without even the slightest karmic obscuration. Nevertheless, the Tathāgata, having looked to the people of later times, showed such a thing so that certain monks who go on alms rounds — when they enter villages, towns, hamlets, provinces, districts, or the environs of royal palaces on alms rounds and, being of little merit themselves, find no alms — will at that moment bring the Tathāgata to mind and say: 'Even the Tathāgata himself, the one in whom every accumulation of wholesome roots is perfectly complete, came out having entered as though emerging with a washed alms bowl. What need is there to speak of us who possess only meager wholesome roots? Let not this failure to obtain alms torment us utterly.' It was with a view to this purpose and benefit that the Tathāgata showed that he went out from the brahmin quarter just as one emerges having washed an alms bowl, having entered it for the sake of alms.

Furthermore, if someone were to say: 'It was because the evil māra had spiritually seized brahmins and householders that they gave no alms in that way,' that too should not be understood as such. And why? Because the evil māra is unable to create an obstacle to the Tathāgata's alms round. Rather, it is by the Tathāgata's own blessing that the evil māra had seized those brahmins and householders — for the Tathāgata had no karmic obscuration whatsoever. It was to bring those very sentient beings to full ripening that the Tathāgata displayed such a skillful means."

During that period when the Tathāgata had cut off and abstained from food, the evil māra and the gods of māra's host, along with other divine sons, wondered whether the ascetic Gautama and his śrāvakas were not sitting in discomfort. In this way, they directed their minds toward the Tathāgata together with his Saṅgha of śrāvakas, thinking on them by day and by night. Yet as they thought on the Tathāgata together with his Saṅgha of śrāvakas in their minds, there was not even a single point in his mind that was elevated or low. Just as it had been before, so it was after; just as it was after, so it had been before — and having rightly perceived that there was no discomfort, at that very time seventy thousand divine sons assembled and prostrated to the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata then taught them the Dharma in such a way as would cause the pure eye of Dharma to arise in all of them with respect to all phenomena. Thus the Tathāgata was looking to future beings, and there was no karmic obscuration in the Tathāgata whatsoever.

Then a question was posed: "Blessed One, it has been said that the brahmin's daughter Sundarī bound a wooden bowl to her belly and slandered the Tathāgata — how are we to understand this?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, there is no fault of karmic obscuration in the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata could indeed have hurled the brahmin's daughter Sundarī to world-realms as numerous as the grains of sand along the Ganges. But the Tathāgata, skilled in means, displayed the workings of karma so that those who would slander the renunciants in this teaching of mine would be slandered with false accusations in return, and so that when they arrived at the point of mere remorse over that slander, they would think: 'Even the Tathāgata, who possesses all white virtues, was openly subjected to slander — why then should we not encounter it as well?' — and having suppressed that slander, they would conduct themselves in the holy life completely pure, completely cleansed, and would not degenerate.

As for the brahmin's daughter Sundarī, she was one whose evil karma had fully proliferated, so that even in dreams she would slander the Tathāgata. After her death she would go to the hell realms.

Son of good family, if the Tathāgata had known that by intervening he would protect her, he would indeed have intervened. And why? Because the Tathāgata had not abandoned any sentient being whatsoever."

Then a question was posed: "Blessed One, it has been said that when the Tathāgata accepted an invitation to spend the rains retreat in the region of Vairāñjā, he was fed horse-fodder barley for three months — how are we to understand this?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, I knew that those brahmins and householders had no intention of inviting the Tathāgata to their homes, and knowing this, the Tathāgata nonetheless spent the rains retreat there. And why? All five hundred horses from whose fodder the Tathāgata together with his Saṅgha of monks ate during those three months had without exception, in a former life, served the Victors as bodhisattvas. Having then fallen under the influence of evil companions and committed evil deeds, those deeds caused them to be born in an animal state of existence.

Among those five hundred horses, the one known as the horse Cañjaka was in fact the bodhisattva named Sūryagarbha, who through the power of aspirational prayer had taken birth there intentionally. Those five hundred horses, moreover, had been caused by that very bodhisattva Sūryagarbha to take hold of genuine awakening. He had therefore been born there in order to bring them to complete maturation, and through the power of that horse Cañjaka, all five hundred horses recalled their former lives without exception, and their awakening minds became manifest. For this reason, son of good family, the Tathāgata spent that rains retreat there out of compassion for those five hundred horses.

Now, half of the fodder that belonged to the horse Cañjaka was offered to the Tathāgata, and from the fodder belonging to those five hundred horses, half by half was offered to the five hundred monks. That horse Cañjaka, in the language of horses, caused those five hundred horses to take the vows of restraint and also caused them to make prostrations to the Buddha and to the five hundred monks.

Son of good family, when those three months had passed, those five hundred horses died and passed on. They were reborn as gods equal in fortune to the

gods of Tuṣita, and those gods, having become divine, honored the Tathāgata, revered him, made offerings and showed him the highest esteem. The Tathāgata in turn taught them the Dharma in whatever way would ensure that they would be determined to attain unsurpassed, genuinely perfect awakening. As for the herdsman who tended and kept those five hundred horses alive, the Tathāgata also prophesied that he would become a pratyekabuddha named Subhadanta, the Gentle-Toothed.

Son of good family, even so, with respect to whatever the Tathāgata ate, there was not the slightest thing lacking in quality. Son of good family, were the Tathāgata to have consumed wood, chaff, husks, or bitter greens and the like, the flavor and supreme tastiness of such wood, chaff, husks, bitter greens, and the like would be something not found throughout the entire great trichiliocosm. Why is this? Because the Tathāgata has obtained what is known as the major mark of a great being — the supreme excellence of taste. Therefore, son of good family, by this token you should understand that all of the Tathāgata's food is of excellent quality.

Son of good family, furthermore, the monk Ānanda thought: "The Tathāgata has renounced the sovereignty of a wheel-turning king and is eating horse fodder," and so he became filled with sorrow. The Tathāgata, perceiving this thought in his mind, said: "Ānanda, do you know what this tastes like?" and gave him a single grain of barley. When Ānanda ate it, he was seized with wonder and exclaimed: "Blessed One, I was born in a royal household and raised well in a royal household, yet a taste such as this I have never before experienced." By giving him that single grain, the venerable Ānanda passed seven days without eating any other food, sustained entirely by joy and bliss.

Son of good family, therefore by this further token as well, you should understand this: the Tathāgata is one who possesses no karmic obscuration of any kind whatsoever. This is to be demonstrated completely just as it was stated — that those sentient beings, those brahmins and householders endowed with moral discipline, did not invite him as a guest or offer him food.

He demonstrated karmic continuities of just that sort. Son of good family, consider further this distinctive greatness of the Tathāgata's essential nature, shared among all the Tathāgatas: even the one who invited a Tathāgata and then did not offer him food was prophesied by the Tathāgata himself as one who would not fall into transgression.

Son of good family, there is yet another instance. Of the five hundred monks who had undertaken to spend the three months of the rains retreat together with the Tathāgata, forty of those monks were engaged in conduct driven by attachment and were dwelling on pleasing signs. Had they, at that time, eaten food obtained by begging, an exceedingly great proliferation of conceptual thought laden with attachment would have arisen in them. Yet because they ate poor food, that conceptual thought laden with attachment became attenuated, and within seven days they actualized arhatship.

Son of good family, therefore whoever rightly understands what has been spoken by the Tathāgatas understands it as something wholly excellent. Son of good family, it is in just this way that a bodhisattva is skilled in understanding what is spoken with a particular intent and what is spoken with definitive meaning.

Thereupon the Blessed One declared these verses:

The bodhisattva who is the very embodiment of compassion
rightly understands what was spoken with provisional intent
and what was spoken with definitive meaning.

Firm in contemplative insight, skilled in its depths,
having abandoned the joining of what does not belong together,
such a one truly comprehends what was spoken
by the perfectly awakened buddha of renowned fame.

Son of good family, why is it that a bodhisattva does not wish to pass into complete nirvāṇa by way of the vehicle belonging to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas? Son of good family, here is the answer: even though a bodhisattva is entirely tormented and scorched by the sufferings of hell-beings, or by the sufferings of animals, or by the sufferings of hungry ghosts, he does not give rise to the wish to pass into complete nirvāṇa by way of the vehicle of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. He does not think in a diminished way, "How wonderful it would be if, without clinging, the mind were to be fully liberated from all defilements!" He does not strive toward something diminished in aim and diminished in action, nor apply himself to what is small in aim and small in deed. Rather, he becomes a companion to sentient beings in their virtuous actions, leads those very sentient beings to properly take hold of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, properly encourages them, and properly causes them to rejoice. Son of good family, that is why a bodhisattva does not wish to pass into complete nirvāṇa by way

of the vehicle of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Thereupon the Blessed One declared these verses:

One who embodies compassion and acts with a mind steadfast as a mountain,
who never wearies in the cause of sentient beings
and never turns back from awakening:
the bodhisattva, wishing to benefit sentient beings, does not grow weary,
and for the sake of benefiting others, does not become heedless.

Then the bodhisattva and great being King Jewel-Moonlight of Pure Stainless Virtue addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, you have declared ten qualities by which a bodhisattva is properly established in the Great Vehicle. But as to the reason why this vehicle is called the Great Vehicle, the Blessed One has not yet spoken."

Upon hearing this, the Blessed One spoke thus to the bodhisattva and great being King Jewel-Moonlight of Pure Stainless Virtue: "Son of good family, therefore, since you yourself are raising this question, receive an answer in accordance with how you yourself understand it. Son of good family, what do you think?

"How would you describe the road along which a wheel-turning king travels together with his fourfold army?"

He replied: "Blessed One, it would be called the king's road. It would be called a great road. It would be called a comfortable road. It would be called a fine road. It would be called a road without obstruction. It would be called a road without confusion."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in just the same way, the vehicle by which a Tathāgata, a foe-destroyer, a perfectly and completely awakened buddha travels is also to be called the Great Vehicle. It is to be called the supreme vehicle, the excellent vehicle, the supremely excellent vehicle, the foremost vehicle, the chief vehicle, the unsurpassed vehicle, the unexcelled vehicle, the unequalled vehicle, the vehicle to which nothing is equal, and the vehicle that is equal to the unequalled. Son of good family, for that reason this Great Vehicle is called the Great Vehicle."

He said: "Blessed One, this Great Vehicle is wonderful. Sugata, this Great Vehicle is wonderful."

Then the wicked Māra thought to himself: "This renunciant Gautama has thoroughly passed beyond my domain of Māra, and he causes others to

thoroughly pass beyond it as well. I shall march against this renunciant Gautama and against this category of Dharma at the head of my fourfold army." And so the wicked Māra donned his armor together with his fourfold army, and set out in the direction of the great city of Rājagṛha and toward Vulture Peak Mountain.

The bodhisattva and great being King Jewel-Moonlight of Pure Stainless Virtue saw the wicked Māra coming with his fourfold army, heading toward the Blessed One and this category of Dharma with the intention of causing it to decline. Seeing this, he performed a display of miraculous power. And by means of the miraculous display he performed, the wicked Māra together with his fourfold army, after entering the great city of Rājagṛha, began to call out and cry aloud along the main roads, the crossroads, and the triple junctions, saying: "People of Rājagṛha, know this! The Tathāgata, foe-destroyer, perfectly and completely awakened buddha, on Vulture Peak Mountain, teaches and thoroughly teaches to his fourfold assembly of monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, and also to non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), a holy life that is good at the beginning, good in the middle, and good at the end, possessed of good meaning, possessed of good words, unmixed, complete, pure, and thoroughly purified. Therefore, come today before the Tathāgata to hear the sacred Dharma, and he will bring you long-lasting welfare, benefit, and happiness." And so he proclaimed this throughout.

Then the kṣatriyas, brahmins, householders, village folk, and country people of Rājagṛha, urged on by the wicked Māra, took up flowers, incense, perfume, garlands, ointments, powders, garments, parasols, victory banners, and pennants, and set out from the great city of Rājagṛha in the direction of Vulture Peak Mountain.

They went to where the Blessed One was, arrived, and prostrated with their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, paid homage to the Blessed One, made obeisance, circumambulated him, made offerings, and then sat down to one side. The wicked Māra, too, departed from the great city of Rājagṛha together with his fourfold host of armies, and went to Vulture Peak Mountain, to where the Blessed One was. On arriving there, he manifested divine flowers — mandārava flowers — and scattered them, showered them, and rained them down upon the Blessed One. Having scattered, showered, and rained them down upon the Blessed One, he sat to one side together with his fourfold host of armies.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Virtuous Immaculate Pure Precious Moonlight King addressed the wicked Māra as he sat to one side, saying: "O Wicked One, why have you come before the Blessed One with your fourfold host of armies?"

Māra replied: "I have come with the intention of obstructing the Blessed One and of creating obstacles to this presentation of the Dharma."

The bodhisattva Virtuous Immaculate Pure Precious Moonlight King said: "O Wicked One, what will you gain by obstructing the Tathāgata and creating obstacles to this presentation of the Dharma? O Wicked One, will that not bring you long-lasting purposelessness, harm, and suffering? You should confess your fault as a fault before the Blessed One."

Then the wicked Māra, upon hearing this concordant counsel and instruction given by the bodhisattva, the great being, Virtuous Immaculate Pure Precious Moonlight King, rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, touched his head to the feet of the Blessed One, and, before the Blessed One, confessed his fault as a fault in these words: "Blessed One, I was childish, confused, obscured, unskilled, and did not know my own measure. I harbored a mind of aversion toward the Blessed One and sought to create obstacles to a sūtra such as this. Blessed One, I wish to confess my fault as a fault. O Sugata, I wish to confess my fault as a fault, and I wish also to restrain myself from it henceforth. May the Blessed One graciously receive and accept this confession of my fault as a fault."

Having thus confessed by way of acknowledging the fault as a fault, the Blessed One declared: "O Wicked One, this is indeed the case: when a fault arises in a son or daughter of good family, if they regard it as purified, regard the fault as a fault, take corrective action, cleanse themselves, and restrain themselves from it henceforth — then this noble, well-proclaimed Dharma and Vinaya will flourish."

Then the wicked Māra rose from his seat, sat before the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, did you not yourself proclaim that harsh speech, in all its entirety and in every aspect, constitutes a path of non-virtuous action?"

The Blessed One declared: "O Wicked One, that is so."

Māra said: "Blessed One, if that is the case, then you, the Blessed One, sovereign of the Dharma — why do you habitually address me by the expression 'Wicked One'?"

The Blessed One declared: "O Wicked One, for that very reason, there are points here that can be known in full through examples — points spoken to wise persons. Listen to an analogy. O Wicked One, consider this: suppose there is a merchant or a householder who is wealthy, rich in goods, possessed of great resources, and has a son who is dear to him, desired, beloved, pleasing — one whose sight brings no displeasure —

and was his only son, and whose livelihood depended on that son's. Yet that only son turned out to be difficult to tame, difficult to reform, and given to deceit. So the merchant or householder would do this to the only son: to turn him back from that wrongdoing, he would strike him with his hand, and strike him with sticks and fists and whatever blows were fitting, and rebuke him with harsh words. What do you think, O Wicked One? Does that merchant or householder strike the only son with thoughts of anger, agitation, hatred, and ill-will?"

Māra replied: "Blessed One, it is not so. O Sugata, it is not so. Blessed One, he strikes him for the sake of his benefit."

The Blessed One declared: "In the very same way, O Wicked One, the Tathāgata, knowing the thoughts and latent tendencies of all sentient beings, tames those sentient beings who are to be tamed by harsh speech with harsh speech; tames those who are to be tamed by gentle speech with gentle speech; tames those who are to be tamed by winning them over with winning them over; tames those who are to be tamed by form with form; and tames those sentient beings who are to be tamed by sound, smell, taste, touch, and phenomena with sound, smell, taste, touch, and phenomena."

Then the Wicked Māra felt gladness and delight and exhilaration and supreme exhilaration and joy and happiness and ease of mind, and bowing his head to the feet of the Blessed One, he addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, in whatever village, town, market town, district, or direction of a district this enumeration of Dharma is recited or held, I too shall come there to benefit the one who listens to the Dharma, who guards and protects and preserves this enumeration of Dharma, and who teaches the Dharma. And let these be known as signs that will precede it: his retinue will become peaceful and free from drowsiness and torpor, and vast, ever vaster gatherings of those who

listen to the Dharma will come to him. The holding, retaining, reading, and expounding of it will not exhaust his body, nor will his mind become exhausted either. And the more he reads, teaches, and expounds this enumeration of Dharma fully and correctly to others, the more his mind will become joyful and supremely joyful and uplifted."

Then the other non-Buddhists — the wanderers and peripatetics who had assembled in that retinue — hearing what Māra had said, developed faith and joy and supreme joy in the Tathāgata.

Thereupon the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, what is the cause and condition by which the teaching of this enumeration of Dharma has produced faith and joy and supreme joy in these non-Buddhist wanderers and peripatetics?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, long ago, in the past, right here in this city of Rājagṛha and on this very Vulture Peak Mountain, there appeared a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and completely awakened buddha named Supreme Strength, Fully Transcendent. He taught this very enumeration of Dharma. And when he taught this enumeration of Dharma, those non-Buddhist wanderers and peripatetics who came were of a somewhat elevated disposition,

and upon hearing this enumeration of Dharma, they did utter the words "Excellent! Excellently taught!" — yet they did not attain faith, joy, and supreme joy toward that Tathāgata. By that cause and that condition, they were born for sixty-eight eons among gods and humans, but apart from that, they never once took birth among hell-beings, animals, or hungry ghosts. Yet because they had not attained faith, joy, and supreme joy toward that Tathāgata, in those other lifetimes, one after another, they were separated from spiritual friends.

Ānanda, if it should occur to you to wonder or to doubt or to be uncertain, thinking 'At that time and in that moment, those other non-Buddhist wanderers and peripatetics — could they have been different persons?' — Ānanda, you should not look at it that way. Why is that? Because these very ones here were at that time and in that moment those other non-Buddhist wanderers and peripatetics.

Ānanda, these ones here, having given rise to faith and joy and supreme joy toward the Tathāgata, were moreover prophesied by the Tathāgata to attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Then, in that very moment of

receiving the prophecy, through that same faith, joy, and supreme joy that had arisen, those non-Buddhist wanderers and peripatetics attained the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena. As this enumeration of Dharma was being taught, twenty-two thousand living beings obtained the Dharma eye — pure, free of dust and stain. Twenty thousand living beings who had not previously generated the awakening mind generated the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Then the venerable Ānanda said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how great a store of merit would be generated by a son of good family or a daughter of good family who takes up this enumeration of Dharma, retains it, reads it, and teaches it widely and correctly to others?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, compared to someone who establishes every sentient being, without exception, in the entire realm of sentient beings in unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — a son or daughter of good family who takes up this enumeration of Dharma, retains it, reads it, and teaches it widely and correctly to others generates merit far more immeasurable and far more abundant. Why is that? Ānanda, it is because this enumeration of Dharma leads to the gnosis of omniscience."

Ānanda asked: "Blessed One, if a son or daughter of good family were to generate a mind of aversion toward this enumeration of Dharma and toward one who teaches the Dharma — Blessed One, how great a store of demerit would that son or daughter of good family generate?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, compared to someone who gouges out the eyes of every single sentient being — a son or daughter of good family who generates a mind of aversion toward this enumeration of Dharma and toward one who teaches the Dharma generates demerit far more immeasurable and far more abundant. Why is that? Ānanda, it is because this enumeration of Dharma is that which illuminates all sentient beings."

Ānanda then asked:

"Blessed One, I will not recite this enumeration of Dharma before those who lack faith — and for this reason: so that, having committed a deed through which all sentient beings would come to be deprived of the Dharma, one might not be born in the hells for sentient beings after the body perishes at death. It is for the sake of guarding against that."

literally "not being གྲོག་ and not speaking གྲོག་པུ་." These terms denote cutting or biting speech, hence rendered as harshness in character and in speech. The distinction is between a harsh disposition and harsh words, which the translation preserves.

- The phrase rendered "island of safety" translates a term meaning literally "island" or "refuge-island," a classical Buddhist image for a place of safety amid the flood of saṃsāra; "island of safety" preserves both the literal image and its doctrinal resonance.

The list of physical abuses — abuse, scolding, striking, smearing with filth, binding, throwing into a pit, expulsion, and tormenting — follows a standard canonical enumeration of the trials against which patience is tested.

The phrase "nirvāṇa without remainder" renders the standard compound for the nirvāṇa in which no psycho-physical aggregates remain, distinguishing it from the nirvāṇa attained while still alive in a body.

- The four close placements of mindfulness (body, feelings, mind, phenomena) and the four right efforts here follow a well-known Abhidharma schema; the four bases of miraculous power likewise correspond to the standard rddhipāda list. The text abruptly breaks off mid-sentence at the end, indicating the passage continues in the source.
- The verse's second line contains the phrase rendered "blazes with light from within its source" — the Tibetan literally reads something like "while still in the place of its origin" suggesting an uncut or unpolished gem already luminous by nature; the contrast with the polished state in line three is intentional and has been preserved.

The phrase rendered "twofold splendor" translates nyis 'gyur, literally "twofold transformation" or "doubled," understood here as the enhanced brilliance of a jewel once polished — a natural metaphor for bodhicitta refined by practice.

- The simile rendered "resounding echo from a cliff" translates brag ca, which refers specifically to the sound of an echo or reverberation from a rock face. It is distinguished here from the general "echo" used just above for gzugs brnyan — note that gzugs brnyan more literally means "reflection" or "image," but given the context pairing it with "not real" and "entirely imputed," the echo rendering follows commentarial usage linking it to the unfindability of a referent.

The phrase rendered "like a bubble on water" for dbu ba rdos pa literally means something like "a bubble or droplet of foam," indicating something that rises and immediately collapses — the image of extreme insubstantiality. "Bubble on water" conveys this faithfully.

The passage on all phenomena being "like a venomous serpent because they are devoid of the knowledge of skillful means" is doctrinally unusual and may reflect a reading that phenomena, when approached without the wisdom of skillful means, are as dangerous as a poisonous snake — a standard canonical simile for the Dharma misapprehended.

- The phrase rendered "effortless path of that dharmadhātu" translates a construction meaning the path of the dharmadhātu that is without effortful striving. The nuance is that having fully apprehended the marks and definitions at the conceptual level, the bodhisattva enters the dharmadhātu's path in a mode free from deliberate exertion, pointing toward a spontaneous or non-fabricated engagement. This is a technically significant soteriological moment in the text.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as the source text provided is incomplete at that point.

- The name of the bodhisattva interlocutor, rendered here as "Virtuous Stainless Pure Precious Moonlight King," translates the Tibetan dge ba dri med rnam dag rin chen zla 'od rgyal po — a lengthy epithet-name common in sūtra literature. It has been rendered literally and consistently throughout.

The passage on not actualizing nirvāṇa directly while nonetheless inclining toward it is a classic Mahāyāna teaching on the bodhisattva's intentional deferral of personal liberation for the sake of all sentient beings. The two analogies (poison and fire) are doctrinally transparent and have been rendered accordingly.

- The verse rendering of "those of broad and clear vision" translates the Tibetan literally as "those possessed of wide eyes," a standard epithet for bodhisattvas indicating the breadth of their compassionate gaze; the figurative rendering is consistent with the doctrinal and literary register.
- The name of the brahmin village is rendered as Pañcaśāla, the standard Sanskrit form for the Tibetan la can (literally "one having la," obscure without the Sanskrit). The land of Verañjā follows the standard Pāli/Sanskrit attestation for this episode found in the Vinaya. The bodhisattva's name — Virtuous, Stainless, Perfectly Pure, Jewel Moonlight King — is a translation of the Tibetan dge ba dri med rnam dag rin chen zla 'od rgyal po, which functions as a proper name and is rendered transparently in English. The passage on "washing an empty bowl" refers to the well-known Vinaya episode in which the Buddha received nothing in his bowl at Pañcaśāla. The phrase "propheied with reference to their lineage" reflects the Yogācāra doctrinal distinction between the śrāvaka lineage and the bodhisattva lineage: the prophecy is understood as pointing to the latent buddha-nature or lineage capacity within those śrāvakas, not as a literal immediate prediction.
- The phrase rendered "I would not dare say that, except out of great presumption" reflects the Tibetan "bdag gis gang 'dod chen pa ma gtogs par," which means "except out of great audacity or presumption on my part." The speaker is saying that only with great impertinence could he possibly assert that such a bodhisattva would not awaken — effectively a strong affirmation that he will awaken. The framing is a rhetorical negative expressing strong certainty.

The statement "Ānanda, if I were to lie down as a corpse" is a reference to an earlier utterance of the Buddha being discussed in this sūtra. The Tibetan names Ānanda explicitly here as the one addressed.

- The name "Dhanapālaka" for the great elephant is supplied from the well-known narrative context; the Tibetan gives only "the great elephant Norkyong" (nor skyong), which is a Tibetan rendering of Dhanapālaka ("guardian of wealth"). The translation uses the Sanskrit name for clarity.

The phrase rendered "ignoble person" for skyes bu dam pa ma yin pa (literally "one who is not a noble person / holy man") applied to Devadatta is deliberately ironic in the original: the text uses the standard honorific construction in reverse. The translation preserves this nuance with "ignoble person."

- The phrase rendered "just as one emerges having washed an alms bowl" describes the Tathāgata departing empty-handed from the brahmin quarter — the simile being that of a person who, having entered to beg for food and received nothing, washes out the unused bowl and leaves. This somewhat indirect idiom is clarified by the explanatory passage that follows it in the text itself.

The final paragraph's logic is subtle: the Tathāgata deliberately displayed the scene of receiving no alms not because māra actually blocked his round (which is impossible), but because it was the Tathāgata's own blessing working through māra to inspire future monks facing the same difficulty. The Tibetan is unambiguous on this point.

- The name Sundarī, rendered here from the Tibetan bram ze'i bu mo dregs ma, literally means "arrogant brahmin girl." The Tibetan dregs ma is an epithet meaning "the proud one" or "the arrogant one," which is traditionally identified with Sundarī, the brahmin woman who slandered the Buddha in a well-known narrative. The translation uses the name Sundarī with the

descriptive paraphrase for clarity.

The phrase "white virtues" renders *dkar po'i chos thams cad*, literally "all white dharmas," a standard idiom for virtuous or meritorious qualities in classical Buddhist literature.

- The horse's name རྩལ་འགམ་ is rendered here as Cañjaka following the likely Sanskrit reconstruction; it is not fully certain. The bodhisattva's name སྤྱུ་ཡག་འཕྲུ་ is straightforwardly "Sūryagarbha" (essence of the sun). The pratyekabuddha's name རྩལ་འགམ་ could also be rendered "Gentle-Minded" rather than "Gentle-Toothed" depending on the Sanskrit behind it; the Tibetan literally means "mind tamed" or "mind gentle," but the name likely reflects a Sanskrit original. This is a genuine uncertainty left in the notes rather than the body. The closing sentence is somewhat condensed and elliptical in the Tibetan; the translation follows the most natural doctrinal sense given the preceding context.

- The phrase rendered "joining of what does not belong together" translates a term that refers literally to making false or inappropriate connections in interpretation, here in the context of misreading the Buddha's words by conflating provisional and definitive teachings.

The bodhisattva's exclamation rendered as "How wonderful it would be if, without clinging, the mind were to be fully liberated from all defilements" reflects an interjection indicating a diminished aspiration, one content with personal liberation alone rather than full buddhahood for the benefit of all beings.

- The passage describes Māra's miraculous compulsion being turned against him: the bodhisattva King Jewel-Moonlight performs a feat of supernatural power that causes Māra himself to become an unwitting herald proclaiming the Buddha's teaching. The Tibetan is straightforward here, though the exact nature of the miracle is left implicit, consistent with the sūtra's narrative style.

- The name of the bodhisattva, rendered here as "Virtuous Immaculate Pure Precious Moonlight King," is a straightforward compound translation of the Tibetan. The text breaks off mid-sentence at the simile of the merchant's son, which continues in the next passage.

- The epithet of the past buddha, "Rabkyi rtsal gyis rnam par gnon pa," means something like "Supremely Victorious through Excellent Strength" or "Fully Transcendent through Supreme Power." The rendering "Supreme Strength, Fully Transcendent" captures the main semantic elements; the exact Sanskrit original is unknown from context alone, and this name may have a more precise technical form in a Sanskrit recension.

- The phrase "patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena" renders "mi skye ba'i chos la bzod pa," the standard Tibetan for *anutpattikadharmakṣānti*, a key technical term denoting the bodhisattva's direct realization that phenomena do not ultimately arise or cease. This is a significant doctrinal milestone on the bodhisattva path and is deliberately rendered with precision.

- The phrase rendered "those who are not noble persons" translates *skyes bu dam pa ma yin pa*, literally "those who are not excellent persons," meaning ordinary beings who have not attained the noble stages of the path. The doctrinal point is that even such persons can, through hearing this teaching, find their way to supreme awakening, which justifies the Blessed One's instruction to teach it openly despite Ānanda's protective instinct.

The closing colophon line is partial and appears to be the title of the larger collection within which this text belongs — the *Mahāratnakūṭa*, the Great Heap of Jewels — a well-known anthology of Mahāyāna sūtras. Only the opening of the colophon is present in the passage; the full colophon would normally conclude with scribal details and translation credits.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.